

Anastasia DRAGHICI

The Last Dragons



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Chapter I

First encounters

I remember the first day I heard about Irina and Dorian Bibescu. It was in 2004, in a small café in Bucharest where books on the occult and dusty newspapers seemed to blend with the cigarette smoke. People who mentioned this couple spoke in hushed tones, as if the mere mention of their names could attract the attention of invisible forces.

Irina Bibescu, née Stănescu, born in 1942, was described as a woman of delicate appearance, yet whose gaze burned with an intensity few could withstand. Her husband, Dorian, a linguist and alchemist, Grand Master of the highly mysterious Order of the Red Dragon, formed a singular duo with her. He was distinguished by his calm and rigour; she by her flexibility and elusive nature. Together, they embodied what one scarcely dared to name: the living survival of a secret tradition passed down for several centuries.

This reputation was accompanied by numerous tales, including that of the spiritual adoption of a French researcher. As a sign of initiatory lineage, they are said to have bestowed upon him the name Radu Dragonescu, which can be translated as ‘Son of the Dragon’. Having become their spiritual heir, charged with preserving the memory and continuity of their tradition, he remained deeply reserved. His silence sometimes seemed to speak louder than the accounts of those who had known him.

This discretion was, moreover, not unique to their heir; it permeated their entire existence. Their lives had always unfolded in relative secrecy. In Bucharest, then in Sibiu, they received rare visitors in dimly lit flats, transformed for the occasion into veritable sanctuaries. Those who claimed to have visited them spoke of conversations devoted to the ‘Red Breath’ and the ‘Blood of the Word’, as well as meditations during which the rhythm of the heart and that of the breath seemed to gradually synchronise among the participants, as if under the influence of a mysterious inner harmony.

At the time, under communism, the authorities saw them as nothing more than marginal intellectuals, but those who knew them understood that they were the last guardians of ancient knowledge, a fragile bridge between myth and reality.

Chapter II

The red winged dragon and the schism

To understand the Order of the Dragon as it came down to the Bibescus, we must go back several centuries, well before modern Romania, to a time when knights bore arms for God and king. The original Order, strictly Christian, died out in the 16th century, taking with it a tradition of loyalty and codified rituals.

But some of its members refused to let the knowledge die. In the remote valleys of the Danube and the Carpathians, they encountered shamans, mystical poets and heirs to the Dacian cults, still alive in the memory of isolated villages. Gradually, a dissident group emerged, seeking to merge chivalric practices with local pagan and esoteric traditions.

It was at this moment that the symbol that would distinguish them was born: the red winged dragon. Where the original Order retained the terrestrial dragon, the embodiment of Christian loyalty and protection, the dissidents opted for a blood-red dragon capable of flight, half solar, half subterranean, a symbol of mastery of vital energy and spiritual emancipation.

The schism was not merely symbolic. It represented a philosophical choice:

- To continue the traditional chivalric mission and remain faithful to the Church.
- Or to open the way to forbidden, secret practices, combining meditation, vital energy and codified rituals, sometimes frightening to the eyes of ordinary mortals.

Ancient witnesses recount that these dissidents lived in remote villages, sometimes on rocky heights, where the proximity of the Danube and the Carpathian forests offered natural refuge from outside surveillance. There, they developed what would become the red breath, the circulation of a vital energy that was both physical and symbolic, as well as the first codified rituals centred around the winged dragon.

Archives are scarce and fragmentary. What is known is often delivered in coded notes, written with inks mixing pigments and blood. Each word seems chosen to preserve secrecy, even at the expense of historical clarity. It is impossible to know where myth ends and reality begins. Accounts vary: some speak of meditation, others of invocations, possession or collective trances.

This schism marked the beginning of a clandestine lineage, passed down from master to disciple, until it reached the Bibescus several centuries later. The figure of the winged dragon became the reference point, the common thread linking the vanished knighthood to modern esoteric practices.

Chapter III

The red masses and the scarlet breath

The first accounts of red masses reached me in a small village in the Carpathian Mountains, from an elderly adept who had now retired, his hands trembling, his gaze evasive. He spoke in hushed tones, as if uttering these words aloud might attract the attention of invisible forces.

Red masses, he explained, were not rituals of violence or black magic in the legendary sense, but codified energetic practices centred on what Irina and Dorian Bibescu called the scarlet breath of the dragon. The scarlet breath was neither a myth nor a tangible object: it was an energy, a vital current that could be felt flowing through one's veins and chakras, perceived in the synchronisation of the heartbeat and in the shivers that ran through the whole body.

The participants settled into temples converted from old churches:

- Central nave, space for collective trances.
- Raised choir, observation area for the master of ceremonies.
- Side aisles, reserved for study and archives.

In the centre, the green marble altar held a human skull modified with wolf fangs, a symbol of strength and ritual protection, a silver chalice and an athame, a ritual dagger used to offer blood to the dragon's energy and the vampiric spirits. Behind the altar, a red copper winged dragon stared out into the room, amplifying the collective concentration and perception.

Red, black, and white candles were arranged in a precise pattern. The shadows they cast created a play of light and movement that plunged the participants into a deep trance. Some reported feeling an invisible force circulating in the room, simultaneous shivers running through their bodies, and perceiving shared hallucinations, synchronised visions that shifted the space between reality and imagination.

These trances were not mere mystical experiences: they were codified and repeated, with every movement, every breath, every gaze having a meaning. The scarlet breath was at once ritual, psychophysiology and symbolic discipline.

Yet, despite the testimonies, absolute secrecy remained. Even the most senior members and those who had left the Order never revealed the full extent of the rituals. Notes and manuscripts are rare. Transmission remained essentially oral, so that the knowledge would never fall into the hands of potential intruders, whether agents of the regime or overly ambitious curious individuals.

What we know for certain is that these rituals produced tangible effects: synchronisation of heart rates, deep trances, collective hallucinations. What we do not know is where discipline ends and the supernatural begins. Red masses remain a space where myth and reality intertwine, and where the boundary between symbolic power and real experience remains deliberately blurred.

Chapter IV

Testimonials from former followers

1. Ana, 68 years old

"I remember a moment when my body was motionless but my mind was moving above the others. I saw a huge black figure with wings like those of the dragon on the altar. It stared at me with its fiery red eyes, then approached and touched my hand. I felt a burning energy coursing through my veins. Some participants were screaming, but I could only stare, paralysed by fear and ecstasy. Afterwards, my breath was broken, and I couldn't utter a word for hours."

2. Mihai, 44 years old

"During the final chant, I felt myself being thrown into an empty space, where I saw the other disciples floating in a glowing void. I heard voices that were not human, whispering in this strange language. I never dared to repeat the syllables. When I came back, I was still shaking, and some seemed to have lost their minds. I no longer knew if I had come from the real world or if I was still trapped in that scarlet breath."

3. Constantin 49 years old

"The temple is plunged into darkness, with only the glow of red, black and white candles illuminating the ancient stones. The air is thick and humid, heavy with the smell of wax, incense, dust and a strange metallic essence. The red copper winged dragon fixed behind the altar seems to be sizing me up. I feel my heart beating faster than my breath.

Irina raises the athame and whispers the first syllables in an unknown language.

The others respond in unison. The vibration of their voices seems to pass through the walls, the stones, my body. Icy shivers run through me, while my limbs become both heavier and lighter at the same time. A feeling of floating takes hold.

The synchronisation is immediate. I can feel the others' breath, their hearts, their breathing. The circle engraved on the floor seems to absorb our energy and redistribute it. I can make out winged shadows in the dark corners. I don't know if they are my hallucinations or real spirits. The atmosphere is palpable, as if the dragon's breath were passing through every being present.

Suddenly, I feel my spirit detach from my body. I float above the circle. My body remains motionless, but I hover over the nave, observing the other disciples. Some levitate imperceptibly, others whisper in voices that are not their own. The candles cast moving shadows that take on animal shapes, sometimes human. A shiver of horror and wonder runs through me simultaneously.

The chants rise, guttural and incantatory. Entities manifest themselves more clearly: dark shapes with glowing eyes, gliding across the walls, sometimes touching the participants. I feel their breath on my neck, an invisible force pushing, pulling and brushing against my skin. The words of the unknown language resonate in my bones and my mind. I understand that these spirits are linked to the scarlet breath.

All the participants see the same visions: winged silhouettes, dancing red flames, moving symbols engraved in the air. Some convulse, others burst into silent tears. I feel my body vibrate to the rhythm of the breath, and a deep voice whispers in my mind:

'Drink, breathe, let the dragon guide you...'

I try to resist, but part of me is carried away by this energy.

I notice that one disciple's voice changes, whispering words I don't understand. Her body trembles, her gaze freezes, then she laughs in a way that is not her own. The spirits seem to be having fun, observing, testing our resistance. Another person levitates a few centimetres above the ground, while her body remains completely still.

The intensity reaches its peak. The chants become a collective howl, synchronised with the beating of our hearts. The spirits stir, some brushing past us, some disappearing into the walls, leaving behind an icy wind and electric shivers. My mind is expanding, but I feel a limit: the energy could consume me if I give in completely.

Little by little, the chants fade. The shadows stretch out, retreat, and the red copper dragon remains motionless, watching silently. I fall back into my body, panting, exhausted and marked. The entities seem to have left a part of themselves with me, a lingering shiver, a whisper in the back of my neck that I will never forget.

The temple returns to calm. The air is dense but still. The scarlet breath gradually fades, leaving behind a feeling of invisible presence, of absolute mystery. I know that I have not only witnessed a ritual, I have crossed a boundary between the human world and the world of shadows."

4. Elena, 56 years old

"One day, one of the disciples levitated completely, her body rising slowly, and multiple voices came out of her mouth. She laughed, cried and screamed all at once. A spirit appeared behind her, moving in the flames and shadows. It seemed to look at each participant, as if judging our courage and endurance. What we saw that night was beyond anything I could have imagined: fear and fascination were inseparable."

5. Alexandru, 40 years old

"There was a time when we all heard screams that seemed to come from the walls. Shadows moved on their own, and an icy breath ran through our bodies. I thought one of the participants was pretending, but no, no one was moving, and yet the movement and sounds were real. I never knew if these spirits were evil or simply guardians of the dragon."

6. Gabriela 52 years old

"I saw Irina and Dorian disappear almost completely into the scarlet blast. I could feel their presence around me, but I could no longer touch or reach them. The chants and incantations were so powerful that I perceived multiple entities, some benevolent, others terrifying, which seemed to feed on our collective energy. I never repeated these rituals. I promised myself I would remain silent."

7. Stefan 64 years old

"life of their own. In the centre, the red copper winged dragon stared at me, motionless and menacing, as if sizing me up.

The master of ceremonies, Irina, stood near the green marble altar, where a human skull with wolf's fangs and a silver chalice lay. She raised the athame, the ritual dagger, and murmured the first syllables in an unknown language. Instantly, I felt a vibration in the air, a dull, insistent energy

running through the walls and floor.

The chants began, mournful and guttural, resonating in my bones. Each word seemed both familiar and terrifying. My heartbeat quickened, and soon I noticed that my breathing was synchronising with that of the other participants. Coldness ran through me, while my hands felt light, almost detached from my body.

Then came the strange sensation: my mind seemed to float above the circle engraved on the floor. I could see my body sitting motionless, while I, or what I had become, drifted above the nave. The candles cast moving shadows that transformed into winged silhouettes, black spirits gliding silently along the walls. Their presence was palpable, yet elusive, as if every glance they exchanged pierced your soul.

Whispers reached my ears, neither human nor entirely foreign, voices that seemed to come from the walls and the dragon itself. My fingers brushed the air, and I felt energy flowing, pulsing, coursing through my body. I no longer knew where my body ended and the space around me began.

At one point, the master of ceremonies raised the athame and made a small cut in his hand. Blood dripped into the chalice, and then a greenish, cold, undulating vapour materialised above Irina. It descended slowly towards her, entering through the top of her skull like living smoke.

His back arched sharply, his eyes rolled back, and his body rose several metres off the ground, stiff and silent, as if pulled by an invisible thread.

At that very moment, I felt a force envelop the entire circle: our legs became light, our feet lost contact with the stone, and we were all lifted a few centimetres off the ground, as if the entity that had just taken hold of Irina was now extending its grip to each of us. The chants rose, more powerful, in a hypnotic crescendo, and the entities seemed to manifest themselves more fully: collective shivers ran through each body, bursts of red light flashed in the darkness, and shadows undulated like living creatures.

I saw some disciples change their voices, whispering words that were not their own. Others trembled, some wept silently, as if overwhelmed by a presence too intense to name. And I... I felt my mind dissolving, absorbed by this scarlet breath, feeling both horror and ecstasy.

Time faded away. I no longer knew how many minutes, hours or eternities had passed. When the singing finally ceased, I fell back into my body, panting, exhausted and changed. The candles flickered gently, the shadows retreated into the walls, and the red copper dragon now seemed motionless, but alert.

I then understood that I had witnessed something that went beyond simple belief or ritual practice. The red masses were not just rites, but a journey into the unknown, a passage where body and mind are laid bare, confronted with entities, spirits, and the untameable energy of the scarlet breath.

I left the temple with the certainty that I would never be the same again, forever carrying the thrill of the shadows and the whisper of dragons in my memories."

Chapter V

An elusive existence

When it comes to Irina and Dorian Bibescu, separating fact from legend becomes almost impossible. Those who claimed to have known them describe two individuals seemingly detached from time itself, living within a parallel reality where ordinary rules held little power. Their lives are said to have unfolded between discreet old residences in Bucharest and Sibiu and secret retreats hidden deep within the Southern Carpathians, far from prying eyes and the noise of the world.

The Red Masses and the ritual known as the Crimson Breath were far more than spiritual practices. They represented a total experience in which every gesture, every breath, every shadow, and every flame contributed to the subtle mastery of vital energy. Yet the intensity of these rites, combined with the secrecy in which they were conducted, is said to have left profound marks on those who took part. Some followers descended into madness, others took their own lives, while a few vanished under circumstances that were never fully explained. Many suspected the involvement of the Securitate, notorious for its determination to eliminate any form of dissent, whether political, intellectual, or spiritual.

The regime's official archives are filled with alarming reports describing vampire invocations, possession rites, exorcisms, and strange blood-related practices. Former members of the Order and the few surviving participants, however, strongly downplay such accounts, portraying their activities as little more than private gatherings among friends devoted to reading, meditation, and philosophical discussion.

This contradiction has sustained a veil of ambiguity that has never entirely lifted. On one side stand the archives, depicting a secret society engaged in dark and unsettling rituals; on the other are the former disciples, who speak of a discreet brotherhood whose legacy belonged more to inner exploration than to magic. Between these incompatible narratives stretches a vast shadowland where memory gradually merges with legend.

This constant tension between exaggeration and minimization has itself become part of the mystery. The rituals were almost never recorded in their entirety. Their transmission remains oral, encoded, and deliberately fragmentary. The purpose was not merely to shield the practices from the scrutiny of the authorities, but also to preserve their integrity from curious outsiders and external interpretations.

At the heart of this secrecy stands Radu Dragonescu, the spiritual heir of the Bibescu couple. A scholar as discreet as he is enigmatic, he is believed to have become the custodian of the Crimson Breath and the memory of the ancient rites. Yet he has steadfastly refused to continue his masters' work or pass on their teachings. According to the few testimonies available, he lives in seclusion on the far side of the world—silent, elusive, and inaccessible—the guardian of a legacy whose true significance no one seems able to measure.

Thus, the modern Order of the Red Dragon survives primarily as a living legend. The Bibescus—perhaps gone, perhaps still dwelling in some forgotten refuge—continue to haunt the memories of those who knew them or sought them out. The Red Masses, the collective trances, the synchronized hallucinations, and the Crimson Breath remain elusive, resisting any complete documentation. Every account, every contradictory testimony, every unexplained disappearance contributes to the creation of a world where myth and reality intertwine so completely that they can never be fully separated, and where secrecy serves simultaneously as a safeguard, an inheritance, and an essential part of the magic itself.

Chapter VI

The Order under Communism

The Iron Curtain descended upon Romania, and with it vanished the freedom of those who dared to think differently. For the Dissident Order of the Dragon, this era became a struggle for survival, marked by fear, violence, and disappearance.

The Bibescu couple, already cautious by nature, found themselves under the constant surveillance of the Securitate. Official reports described them as a “suspicious couple practicing a philosophy of blood and breath,” yet every detail appears exaggerated, amplified to justify espionage and infiltration. Agents embedded within their circles reported tales of occult rites—exorcisms, vampire invocations, and spirit possession—fueling the legends and rumors that increasingly surrounded the Order.

In reality, adherents were subjected to brutal arrests, relentless interrogations, and, at times, torture, all intended to extract secrets that the Order’s masters refused to reveal. Some were sent to prisons or labor camps; others were confined to psychiatric institutions and declared insane in order to neutralize their influence. Many disappearances remained unexplained. Survivors spoke in hushed voices of staged murders, forced deportations, and imposed silence, though it was often impossible to separate fact from legend.

Despite the repression, the Red Masses and the ritual of the Scarlet Breath continued in secrecy, becoming more concealed and more codified than ever before. Irina and Dorian maintained the practice in remote locations—sometimes deep within the mountains, sometimes along the banks of the Danube—inside improvised sanctuaries designed to mirror the symbolic structure of ancient churches.

The green marble altar, the wolf-fanged skull, the winged dragon of red copper, and the candles arranged according to a precise pattern were placed with meticulous care to encourage collective trances. The reported phenomena—physiological changes and synchronized hallucinations—appeared to persist, yet every gesture was now encoded and performed with extreme caution to avoid unwanted attention.

Former disciples still recount those nights when the flickering light of red, black, and white candles cast shifting shadows across the walls, and the winged dragon of red copper seemed to come alive with every breath. Even under constant pressure from the authorities, the masters preserved the coherence of the rituals and the oral transmission of their teachings, refusing to commit instructions to writing where they might fall into the wrong hands.

For the Bibescus and their Order, secrecy was first and foremost a means of survival. Yet that very secrecy also nourished the legend. Witnesses spoke of disappearances, suicides, and mysterious illnesses among the followers, while the authorities exaggerated events to reinforce fear and suspicion. The members themselves downplayed their involvement, describing their activities as little more than friendly gatherings, reading circles, and meditation sessions.

Thus, under the communist regime, the Order of the Red Dragon became both a target and a myth. It survived through secrecy, discipline, and unwavering devotion to its teachings. The trials of this period forged the legend of the Bibescu family and prepared the way for the next generation, of which Radu Dragonescu would become the silent heir.

Chapter VII

Post-communism

The fall of the communist regime in 1989 did little to shed light on the Order of the Red Dragon. On the contrary, it seemed to deepen the veil of mystery surrounding Irina and Dorian Bibescu. Freed from the constant surveillance of the Securitate, they chose to retreat to the Southern Carpathians, to a secluded retreat accessible only to a few carefully selected disciples.

It was in this context of voluntary seclusion that the figure of Radu Dragonescu emerged. Around 2005, the couple adopted him spiritually when he was forty-three years old. A passionate researcher of the occult sciences and long fascinated by the Order's archives, he was given the name "Son of the Dragon" and became the heir to the scarlet breath. Under their guidance, he learned to master the breathing techniques associated with vital energy and to perceive what the initiates called the Black Waters. But he also discovered the spiritual cost of these practices. Unlike those who had come before him, he ultimately chose not to pass this legacy on to anyone, fearing it would be distorted, misunderstood, or turned into an instrument of power.

This refusal to pass on the knowledge further deepened the mystery surrounding the Order. The exact rituals remain unknown today: the content of the red masses, the periods of fasting, the invocations of spirits, the practices of exorcism, or the phenomena of possession cannot be confirmed by any independent source. Adding to this opacity are disturbing accounts concerning former adherents, some of whom are said to have descended into madness or taken their own lives. Other rumors suggest the involvement of former secret police agents, who are said to have continued, long after the regime's fall, to monitor the most discreet esoteric movements.

The very fate of the Bibescus remains uncertain. Officially withdrawn from the world, they are said to have died several years ago; yet some claim they still live in the shadows of the mountains. As for Radu Dragonescu, he is said to lead a secluded life, faithful to his masters' discretion, refusing all media attention and public statements.

This lack of certainty has fueled new legends. Witnesses report that at each equinox, a strange reddish glow sometimes appears above the Danube, while an abnormally hot breath cuts through the air despite the surrounding cold. This phenomenon, which local traditions refer to as *Răsuflarea Roșie*—the "Red Breath"—is often presented as the last visible echo of the ancient brotherhood.

Thus the legend of the Order of the Red Dragon endures, straddling the boundary between history and myth. It is a world where discipline, symbolism, and inner power intertwine; where secrecy serves as the guardian of the masters' memory; where the transmission of knowledge itself remains contingent upon a form of spiritual dignity. The scarlet breath, the Black Waters, and the image of the winged dragon continue to inhabit the imagination of those interested in this tradition, linking the past to the present in a gray area where no one can say with certainty what belongs to history and what to legend.

